Lesson 22: Thesis Statements

English Stage 3 (C1) · Unit 3: Paragraphs, Essays and Cohesion

Adapted from College ESL Writers: Applied Grammar and Composing Strategies for Success by Barbara Hall and Elizabeth Wallace, Georgia State University - Perimeter College (CC BY-NC-SA): 4.2: Developing a Strong, Clear Thesis Statement; and from Reading, Writing, Research, and Reasoning: An Advanced ESL Text by Gabriel Winer and Elizabeth Wadell, ASCCC Open Educational Resources Initiative (CC BY-NC 4.0): 2.3: Writing a Thesis Statement.

In this lesson

You will learn what a thesis statement does, what makes it strong, and how to revise a weak or working thesis. Both books in your lesson material teach this, and this guide brings their advice together. You will evaluate and improve the books' sample thesis statements and write the working thesis for your Unit 3 essay: a clear thesis is the first thing a university instructor looks for in any essay.

Learning goals

After this lesson you should be able to:

- Explain what a thesis statement does and where it usually appears.
- Evaluate a thesis: is it specific, precise, arguable, demonstrable, forceful and confident?
- Recognize weak thesis statements: announcements, obvious facts, outrageous claims, statements that are too broad, and personal opinions.
- Revise a working thesis by replacing nonspecific words, asking questions and including organization language.

Key language

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
thesis statement	the sentence (sometimes two) that gives the main idea of the whole essay	the "sign" that readers follow through your essay
working thesis	an early version that guides your planning and will probably change	You may change it again before the final draft.
arguable	someone might disagree with it	not an obvious fact
specific / precise	focused on one area of a topic / making an exact claim about it	limited options exist for those who are uninsured by their employers
demonstrable	able to be supported with reasons and examples	A worthy argument is backed by examples and details.
forceful / confident	assertive, taking a stance others might oppose / without "I feel" or "I believe"	Your opinion is more convincing when you use a firm attitude.

Word or phrase	Meaning	Example
nonspecific words	vague words that cover too much	people, everything, society, life
linking verb / action verb	a verb that only connects (*are, is*) / a verb that expresses action	are not paid enough → cannot afford to pay
signal words	thesis language that shows how the essay is organized	although, it is necessary to, result in

Rules and explanations

What a thesis does

- A topic sentence summarizes a paragraph; a **thesis statement summarizes the whole essay**. It states the point you want to make, and the essay explains, justifies and supports that point.
- Both books compare it to a **sign** showing readers where the essay is going. Without it, readers cannot see how the examples fit together.
- It is not the topic itself but **your interpretation** of it. Ask yourself, "What do I want to say about it?" If your instructor gives you a question, your thesis is generally the answer to it.

Form and position

- Usually **one sentence** (Winer and Wadell: sometimes two), **toward the end of the introduction**.
- It focuses on **one to three points** of a single idea that the body can demonstrate, and suggests how the essay is organized.
- Write a **working thesis** before you organize the essay, and revise it as the essay develops.

Qualities of a strong thesis

Quality	What it means
Specific	It concentrates on one area of a general topic (health care → options for individuals without health care coverage). A broad thesis makes the argument unclear and unfocused.
Precise	It makes an exact claim about that area (limited options exist for those who are uninsured by their employers).
Arguable	Someone might disagree: it is not an obvious fact or something everyone already knows.
Demonstrable, not just personal opinion	You can support it with reasons and examples, from personal observations or outside sources, that persuade other people. A personal opinion alone will not.
Forceful	The tone is assertive and takes a stance that others might oppose.
Confident	No "I feel", "I believe" or "in my opinion", even in a personal essay: these phrases reduce your credibility.

The four "Examples of Appropriate Thesis Statements" in the lesson material (closing borders, no-fault divorce, drug education, the high school diploma) each meet several of these requirements.

Weak thesis statements

Problem	Book's example
It only declares the subject or describes what the essay will discuss.	My paper will explain why imagination is more important than knowledge.
It makes an unreasonable or outrageous claim or insults the opposing side.	Religious radicals across America are trying to legislate their Puritanical beliefs ...
It states an obvious fact that no one can disagree with, or leads to a dead end.	Advertising companies use sex to sell their products.
It is too broad.	The life of Abraham Lincoln was long and challenging.

Revising a working thesis

A working thesis often becomes stronger as you gather information and form new opinions. At the end, check that it covers exactly what your essay discusses. Then use these techniques:

1. **Replace nonspecific words** (both books). *People should learn to recognize their biases.* → *Teachers should be required to attend trainings each year to allow them to overcome their biases.*
2. **Ask questions to clarify ideas and add key information** (both books). For *Implicit biases lead to problems with healthcare*, ask: What kinds of problems? How important are they? What are the effects? Revised: *Implicit bias is a major cause of inequalities in healthcare, leading to African American patients getting undertreated for illnesses and decreased life expectancy*. Questions also help you replace vague words ("The welfare system is a joke") and weak **linking verbs**: *DeKalb County schoolteachers are not paid enough → The DeKalb County legislature cannot afford to pay its educators, resulting in job cuts and resignations ...*
3. **Omit general claims that are hard to support** (Hall and Wallace). A claim about all "today's teenage girls" is not true of all girls; questions such as *Which teenage girls? Why are they behaving that way? What are the repercussions?* lead to a narrower claim.
4. **Include organization language** (Winer and Wadell, Table 2.3.1):

Organization	Signal words	Book's example
Concession	although, while, despite, in spite of	[Although] there are clear problems with stereotypes, it is impossible to totally eliminate them from our thinking.
Solutions	we must, it is necessary to, can be overcome by, solve	Given that biases develop early in life, [it is necessary to] develop anti-bias programs for preschool children.
Causes/effects	cause, effect, lead to, result in	Better education programs for police will [result in] fewer biases and improved safety for all members of the community.

Practice

Exercise 1. Noticing organization (Winer and Wadell, "Notice this!"). Read the two short passages about stereotypes (the student from Kuwait) in the lesson material. Which is easier to understand? Why?

Exercise 2. Evaluating thesis statements (Winer and Wadell, "Try this!"). Decide if each thesis is effective, not arguable, not specific, or just a personal opinion. Some have more than one problem.

1. Stereotypes are bad.
2. I think that we should overcome biases.
3. There are benefits and drawbacks to going to another country and learning about a new culture.
4. I don't like it when people make assumptions about me and what I can do.
5. Overall, McRaney and her colleagues make an understandable and compelling argument for the existence of stereotype threat; the information they present is engaging, seems balanced, and helped me make sense of my own experiences.

Exercise 3. Weak or strong? (Hall and Wallace, second exercise). Identify each thesis as weak or strong. For the weak ones, list the reasons and write a revision.

1. The subject of this paper is my experience with snakes as pets.
2. The government must expand its funding for research on renewable energy resources in order to prepare for the impending end of oil.
3. Edgar Allan Poe was a poet who lived in Baltimore during the nineteenth century.
4. In this essay, I will give you lots of reasons why slot machines should not be legalized in Baltimore.
5. Despite his promises during his campaign, President Kennedy took few executive measures to support civil rights legislation.
6. Because many children's toys have potential safety hazards that could lead to injury, it is clear that not all children's toys are safe.
7. My experience with young children has taught me that I want to be a disciplinary parent because I believe that a child without discipline can be a parent's worst nightmare.

Exercise 4. Improving thesis statements (Winer and Wadell, "Try this!"). Improve each one by making it more specific, adding key information or including organization language.

1. Stereotypes are bad and keep people from seeing the real me.
2. Categorizing people is a natural function of the brain and identifying stereotypes reduces them.
3. Stereotypes are painful and lower a person's self-esteem.
4. Education is the way to overcome biases.

Speak with your tutor

- "Here is my working thesis: [paste]. Ask me the questions a reader would want answered (Who? What exactly? Why? What are the effects?). Then help me add the key information."

- "Disagree with my thesis: [paste]. If you cannot find a reasonable way to disagree, tell me why it is not arguable."
- "Here are my thesis statements for the five topics in Hall and Wallace's first exercise (texting while driving, the legal drinking age, and so on): [paste]. Is each one specific, precise, demonstrable, forceful and confident?"
- "Check my answers to Exercises 2 and 3 in the lesson material."

Read aloud

Pause briefly at each |.

1. A thesis is not the topic itself, | but rather your interpretation of the question or subject.
2. Although there are clear problems with stereotypes, | it is impossible to totally eliminate them from our thinking.
3. Given that biases develop early in life, | it is necessary to develop anti-bias programs for preschool children.
4. Your opinion is more convincing | when you use a firm attitude.
5. Working thesis statements often become stronger | as you gather information | and form new opinions and reasons for those opinions.
6. Word stress: THE·sis, STATE·ment, spe·CIF·ic, pre·CI·sion, AR·gu·a·ble, CON·fi·dence.

Writing task

The working thesis for your Unit 3 essay (Winer and Wadell, "Apply this!"). Use your narrowed topic from Lesson 21: for example, stereotype threat and how schools can reduce it, stress and coping in first-year students, sleep and memory, or a topic from the book.

1. Ask yourself, "What do I want to say about my topic?" Write a working thesis of one sentence.
2. Check it against the qualities of a strong thesis and the list of weak theses.
3. Revise it: replace nonspecific words, ask key questions, and include organization language.
4. Write both versions. Under the revised thesis, list the two or three points your body paragraphs will develop.

Self-editing checklist

- My thesis is one sentence that could end my introduction.
- It is arguable: a reasonable reader could disagree.
- It is specific and precise, with no nonspecific words such as *people*, *society* or *life*.
- I can demonstrate it with reasons, examples and evidence.
- It does not announce the essay ("In this essay I will ...") and contains no "I think", "I believe" or "in my opinion".
- It uses action verbs, and its signal words show how my essay is organized.
- It focuses on one to three points, and each point can become a body paragraph.

Paste your draft into the chat and ask your tutor for feedback. Then rewrite it.

Answer key

Exercise 1 The second passage (book), because it contains a main idea sentence: both the writer and the new classmates had stereotypes based on limited information from the media. Readers can then see how the two examples fit together.

Exercise 2

1. Not arguable (almost everyone agrees) and not specific (Which stereotypes? Bad in what way?).
2. Just a personal opinion ("I think"), not specific (Who is "we"? Which biases?) and not arguable (few people would disagree).
3. Not arguable (almost every experience has benefits and drawbacks) and not specific.
4. Just a personal opinion: it describes the writer's feelings. It is also not arguable (no one can argue with a feeling) and not specific.
5. Effective: specific (one chapter, three qualities), arguable (a reader could find the chapter unconvincing) and supported with evidence. It is the thesis of the model essay in Lesson 20.

Exercise 3 (revisions are example answers)

1. Weak: it only declares the subject; there is no controlling idea. Revision: *Snakes make good pets for busy people because they are quiet, need little space and require little daily care.*
2. Strong: specific, arguable, forceful and demonstrable.
3. Weak: an obvious fact that no one can argue with (a dead end). Revision: *Edgar Allan Poe's poems about death and loss reflect the losses in his own life.*
4. Weak: it announces the essay ("In this essay, I will"), and "lots of reasons" is vague and informal. Revision: *Legalizing slot machines in Baltimore would increase gambling addiction and harm low-income families more than it would help the city's budget.*
5. Strong: specific, precise and arguable, and it can be demonstrated with historical evidence.
6. Weak: obvious and circular. The reason (toys have safety hazards) already says the conclusion (not all toys are safe), so no one could disagree. Revision: *The government should require independent safety testing for all toys sold for children under three.*
7. Weak: "I believe" makes it unconfident, it is about the writer's personal plans, and "a parent's worst nightmare" is vague. Revision: *Consistent discipline in early childhood helps children develop self-control.*

Exercise 4 (example answers)

1. Stereotypes about international students lead teachers and classmates to judge them by their nationality rather than by their individual abilities.
2. Although categorizing people is a natural function of the brain, learning to identify our own stereotypes can reduce their effect on how we treat others.
3. Negative stereotypes about academic ability can lead to lower test scores and less class participation among students from stereotyped groups.

4. Biases against international students can be partly overcome by education that gives local and international students regular opportunities to work together in class.

My notes